SOP-IT-002 · Reading room and helper access: browser first, a token only if needed

SOP IT-002 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-01 | For Members and their helpers

Department: IT · **ID:** 002 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** organisation administrator · **Last changed:** 2026-11-01

Purpose

The steps a member follows to read an organisation's private repositories, and the steps for letting an AI helper read the same selected material, with the smallest credential that fits. The reasoning lives in proposal THEF 012 and in `my-template/org-onboarding/ACCESS-AND-PATS.md`; this is only the procedure.

Scope

Any person given access to an organisation's private repositories, and their helper. Not for treasury keys, recovery codes or passwords.

Roles

Role	Does
Member	signs in, reads, asks for a helper if wanted
Administrator	invites, approves token requests, verifies as the member
Helper	reads only what it is granted; never receives a secret in chat

Steps: read as yourself

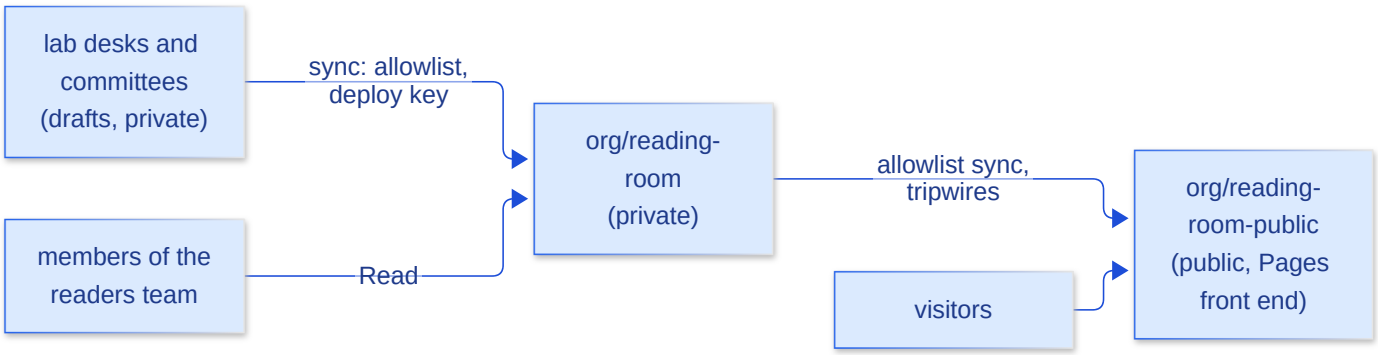
1. Sign in to GitHub with your own account and two-factor authentication on. *You should see:* your avatar top right.
2. Accept the organisation invitation (email or the bell icon). *You should see:* the organisation under your profile's Organizations.
3. Open the repository link you were given, then one README and its PDF under `pdf/`. *You should see:* the page, not a 404. A 404 on a private link means permission is absent: tell the administrator which account you are signed in as.
4. Reply where you already talk to the organisation, or open an Issue if your role allows.

Steps: bring a helper, optionally

1. Ask whether the helper already has an approved GitHub connection that reaches the repository. *If yes:* stop here.
2. If a credential is required, create a **fine-grained personal access token** in your own account: resource owner = the organisation; only the repositories needed; **Contents: Read-only** (plus the metadata GitHub requires); a short expiry. *You should see:* the token once; copy it only into the helper's own credential store.
3. The administrator approves the request if the organisation requires approval. *You should see:* the token's status change from pending to active.
4. Ask the helper to read one named README and summarise it without changing anything. *You should see:* a correct summary and no commit.
5. Record owner, purpose, repositories, expiry and who can revoke, in the organisation's private onboarding notes. Never the token.
6. Revoke or rotate when the purpose ends, the role changes, a device is lost, or exposure is suspected.

The reading-room route (organisation-owned)

A **reading room** is where an organisation's people read drafts that are not public yet, with a public room beside it for what is ready for visitors. Psanctuary Church's addresses are filled in below (checked 2026-11-01); the church's `.github` profile and its onboarding page link here.



The sync's rule and the tripwires are in SOP-OPS-003; the readers team and the base permission in SOP-GOV-002.

Piece	What it is	Psanctuary Church
Private room	`<org>/reading-room`: an **organisation-owned** private repository holding the drafts the organisation's people may read (proposals, procedures, decks). Its README is the index; PDFs sit beside the markdown	github.com/psanctuarychurch/reading-room (private; its README is the index)
Readers team	`<org>/<readers-team>` (for example `readers`), a closed team with **Read** on the private room and nothing else	github.com/orgs/psanctuarychurch/teams/readers: `readers`, closed, created 2026-10-31; members are added only on an officer's yes
Public room	`<org>/reading-room-public`: a public repository that receives **only allowlisted pages** from the private room, with a GitHub Pages front end in the house style	psanctuarychurch.github.io/reading-room-public (repository: psanctuarychurch/reading-room-public)
How drafts arrive	a sync workflow in the source (the `sync-public-allowlist.yml` shape: tripwire first, a deploy key per destination), never hand edits	Lab desk → private room: `READING-ROOM-ALLOWLIST-psanctuarychurch.txt` in the lab's Psanctuary hub (workflow `sync-reading-room-psanctuarychurch.yml`, secret `READING_ROOM_DEPLOY_KEY_PSANCTUARYCHURCH`). Private room → public room: `PUBLIC-ALLOWLIST.txt` in `reading-room` (workflow `sync-public.yml`, secret `READING_ROOM_PUBLIC_DEPLOY_KEY`). Both lists start empty; both workflows do nothing until their secret exists

Why organisation-owned: a personal private repository cannot give anyone read-only access (the 422 below), and Pages on a private repository publishes **publicly** on the free plan, so a members-only website is not available today. The private room's front end is therefore the repository itself (README index, PDFs, decks); the public room is the website. A members-only site (an access gate in front of a Pages build, or GitHub Enterprise) is the later option.

Where the church stands (2026-11-01). Both rooms exist and are pushed: `reading-room` (private, Read for the `readers` team only) and `reading-room-public` (public, deletion-only ruleset, Pages built at the address above). The `readers` team exists with no readers yet (GitHub lists the owner who created it as its one member). The organisation's base permission is **No permission** (SOP-GOV-002), so the team is the true list of who reads the room. Nothing reaches either room automatically until an owner adds the deploy keys (one per

destination); the public room's allowlist now names `000 Start here`, the universal procedures and their icons, and they travel on the first sync after the key exists.

Steps: steward (once per organisation)

1. Create both rooms (an owner's action): `gh repo create <org>/reading-room --private` and `gh repo create <org>/reading-room-public --public`. *You should see:* both under the organisation's repositories.
2. Create the team and grant Read on the private room only:

```
gh api -X POST orgs/<org>/teams -f name=<readers-team> -f privacy=closed
gh api -X PUT orgs/<org>/teams/<readers-team>/repos/<org>/reading-room -f permission=pull
```

3. Add readers on an officer's yes: `gh api -X PUT orgs/<org>/teams/<readers-team>/memberships/<login>` (the same shape as SOP-GOV-001).
4. Give the public room a deletion-only ruleset (its sync force-pushes; SOP-OPS-002 legend) and turn on Pages from `main`.
5. Fill in the table above with the real addresses; link it from the organisation's `.github` README.

Steps: reader

1. Accept the organisation invitation and the team, then open the private room's README. *You should see:* the index, not a 404.
2. Read in the browser, or open a PDF from `pdf/`. To bring a helper, follow *bring a helper* above, choosing only `reading-room` in the token's repository selection.

Verification

The member opens the page from their own account; the helper's read test passes; the administrator can see the token under the organisation's personal access tokens with the expected scope.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
A read-only invitation to a personal (not organisation) private repository fails with 422	GitHub offers no read-only collaborator on personal repositories	use the organisation-owned repository as the door; never grant write and call it read-only
The token works for public repositories only	approval pending	the administrator approves it
The helper cannot reach a repository the member can	token's repository selection excludes it, or an outside-collaborator limitation	adjust selection, or move to organisation membership / an approved GitHub App

Related

- SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* (where a newcomer starts), SOP-GOV-002 *GitHub collaboration*, SOP-OPS-003 *Private houses everything, public lanes witness*
- Proposal: THEF 012 *Your reading room, and how your helper joins you*
- `my-template/org-onboarding/ACCESS-AND-PATS.md`
- SOP-OPS-002 (a helper opens pull requests but does not merge; the legend), SOP-GOV-001 (the Board's room uses the same team shape)
- `my-template/workflow-templates/sync-public-allowlist.yml` (how drafts reach a room)

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-10-30	Drafted from Littlebird's access draft and the Oct 30 verification	Alfred
2026-10-31	The generic reading-room route: an organisation-owned private room, a readers team with Read, a public room with a Pages front end, a fill-in address table	Alfred
2026-11-01	Lucid pass: Lucide icons, the route drawn in Mermaid; links to SOP-OPS-003 (the tripwires) and SOP-GOV-002 (teams, base permission none); new readers start at SOP-COM-001	Alfred
2026-10-31	Filled in for Psanctuary Church: the private room, the `readers` team (created), the public room and its Pages address, both allowlists and secrets by name	Alfred
2026-11-01	Psanctuary Church: the lucid pass taken in; where the church stands, now that both rooms exist and the base permission is none	Alfred